SMALL-GROUP STUDY PACKET

UNDERSTANDING STRUCTURE

Reading the Bible the way its authors built it

TAUGHT BY **Lincoln Fitch** · DiscipleMakers

SESSION November 2, 2026

HOSTED BY **LEFC|U** · Lancaster Evangelical Free Church

FROM YOUR TEACHING PASTOR

A NOTE FROM TOM

Dear Friends,

One of my favorite life principles is summarized in the Japanese word "kaizen," which means "continuous improvement." Paul encourages his disciple Timothy to "Practice these things, immerse yourself in them, so that all may see your progress" (1 Timothy 4:15). That progress is at the heart of Equipped.

Whether you're new to studying Scripture or you've been a student of the Bible for decades, there are always opportunities to learn new skills or sharpen existing ones. Even professional athletes go to spring training!

This packet has been prepared as a complement to the training video on biblical structure we recorded in 2026. My prayer is that this video might edify you as you strive to rightly divide the Word of God for yourself, or prepare to do it for others in your family, small group, or church.

Continue to practice these things, immerse yourself in them, so that all may see your progress!

Blessings,

Tom Daly · Teaching Pastor · LEFC

START HERE

HOW TO USE THIS PACKET

This packet follows the order of Lincoln Fitch's Equipped Training on structure. It rebuilds the printed handout from the session, adds the maps Lincoln used, and prints every passage he had the room read, in the order he used them. Work through it in one long session or across four or five group meetings.

> **The goal:** stop handing people "a pile of bones" — a list of interesting observations about verse 7 and verse 23 — and start showing them the *skeleton*: how the author put the passage together and where he put the weight.

ON SCREEN · 4:40

There's a big difference between being wowed and being equipped.

Watching the video? Every key principle Lincoln puts on screen is printed in a steel **On screen** box like this one, with its time in the video. The lists that build on the right of the screen are on the next page, word for word. You'll need a Bible (the passages are printed here in the ESV), a pen, and a couple of highlighters.

Contents

- Lists to watch for (text types · verbs · connectors)

1 What is structure? Why does it matter?

2 How to find structure: text types and their tools

3 Discourse tools: verbs, participles, and connectors

4 Practice: 1 Peter 5:5–7 · Hebrews 12:1–13

5 Poetry tool: imagery · Practice: Psalm 23

6 Narrative tool: the narrative arc

7 Structure in Judges & Ruth: context clues

8 Maps: the conquest and the judges' homelands

9 Other tools: macro structure, the Judges cycle, leaders, the narrator

10 Practice: Judges 1 & 21 · Judges 2:11–23 · Judges 16 · Ruth 1

11 Leader notes and answer guide

Suggested group plan

Meeting	Read & discuss	Passages
1	Sections 1–3	Matthew 28:18–20 · Romans 8:1 · 1 Peter 5:5–7
2	Section 4 (cont.) & 5	Hebrews 12:1–13 · Psalm 23
3	Sections 6–8	Judges 8 · Deuteronomy 17 · Judges 1:19; 4:1–3
4	Sections 9–10	Judges 1:1–7; 21:24–25 · Judges 2:11–23
5	Section 10 (cont.)	Judges 16:1–31 · Ruth 1:1–5

VIEWING GUIDE

LISTS TO WATCH FOR

When Lincoln teaches a list, the video builds it on the right side of the screen one item at a time, in this order and with these words. Tick each item as it appears; the worksheets in Sections 2 and 3 use the same lists.

LIST A · ~13:03 · TOOLS ~16:12–17:38

Text types

1. **Narrative**
   Key tool: narrative arc
2. **Poetry**
   Key tool: imagery
3. **Discourse**
   Key tool: grammar · flow of thought
4. **Apocalyptic**
   Key tool: a blend of the tools

The four types appear first; each key tool appears under its type as Lincoln names it. See Section 2.

LIST B · ~19:07–21:29

Verb observation

1. **Tense**
   present · past · future
2. **Mood**
   indicative · imperative · subjunctive · interrogative
3. **Voice**
   active · passive
4. **Aspect**
   one-time · ongoing action
5. **Participles**
   support the main verb

See Section 3 and Matthew 28:18–20.

LIST C · ~22:07–23:29

Connectors

CAUSE / EFFECT

1. so that
2. therefore
3. for
4. in order that
5. if… then
6. because

COMPARISON / CONTRAST

7. as well as
8. likewise
9. similarly
10. but
11. instead
12. or

See Section 3, then box every connector in 1 Peter 5:5–7 and Hebrews 12:1–13.

Times are approximate positions in the session video. Try it: before the video gets there, cover this page and see how many of each list your group can name.

SECTION 1

WHAT IS STRUCTURE? WHY DOES IT MATTER?

Lincoln drew two things on the board: a skeleton and a pile of bones. They have the same parts, but only one is a *structure*. A body's structure does something and shows you something. A pile of bones doesn't. Bible teaching can be the same way: a string of cool observations ("look at verse 7… and check out verse 23…") is a pile of bones. We get closer to the voice of the text when we pay attention to its structure.

KEY PRINCIPLE 1

ON SCREEN · 9:33

Every text has a structure.

ON SCREEN · 9:42

Structure is how the author has organized his material to accomplish his goal.

ON SCREEN · 10:04

"Every book has a skeleton hidden between its covers."

Mortimer Adler · *How to Read a Book*

Adler (with Charles Van Doren) goes on: "Your job as an analytical reader is to find it."

KEY PRINCIPLE 2

ON SCREEN · 10:34

Structure reveals emphasis.

When you see how a passage is built, you see what the author wants you to see most. Lincoln puts the two together:

ON SCREEN · 11:44

Every text has a structure, and structure reveals emphasis.

Discuss. Have you ever heard (or taught) a "pile of bones" Bible study? What was missing?

SECTION 2

HOW TO FIND STRUCTURE

Before you look for structure, ask: **What kind of text is this?** Then use the right tool. Using the wrong tool for the job is like trying to tighten a screw with a hammer.

ON SCREEN · 14:44

Different text types require different tools.

Each text type has a key tool. On-screen list A · Text types

Text type	Key tool	What to look for
Narrative	Narrative arc (plot)	Setting, conflict, rising tension, climax, resolution, new setting. Emphasis usually sits at the climax or in the change from the old setting to the new.
Poetry	Imagery	The pictures the writer uses, and where the picture changes (Psalms, Ecclesiastes, the songs in Judges 5).
Discourse	Grammar / flow of thought	Main verbs, participles, and connector words that link ideas (the letters).
Apocalyptic	A blend	Combines the tools above: imagery, story movement, and argument.

ON SCREEN · 16:12

In poetry, imagery is the key tool.

ON SCREEN · 16:52

In narrative, the key tool is the narrative arc.

ON SCREEN · 17:21

In discourse, the key tool is grammar, which shows the flow of thought.

Discuss. Think of the last passage you studied or taught. What kind of text was it? Which tool would have helped most?

SECTION 3 · DISCOURSE

GRAMMAR & CONNECTORS

In discourse (a letter or a sermon), the structure lives in the grammar. Ask two questions as you read: **Do the verbs change?** and **How do the ideas relate?**

VERBS ON-SCREEN LIST B

Feature	Options	In plain English
Tense	present, past, future	When? (“I went”)
Mood	indicative, imperative, subjunctive, interrogative	A statement, a command, an “if / may,” or a question
Voice	active or passive	Am I doing it, or being acted upon?
Aspect	one-time or ongoing action	Once, or again and again?

PARTICIPLES

Participles are “baby verbs,” verbs that aren’t sure what they’re going to be yet. In English they are usually (not always) the *-ing* words. **Participles usually support the work of the main verb.**

> **Matthew 28:18–20** ESV
>
> *The one imperative is “make disciples.” Going, baptizing and teaching show how it is done.*
>
> 18 And Jesus came and said to them, “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. 19 Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, 20 teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

CAUSE / EFFECT CONNECTORS ON-SCREEN LIST C

so that · therefore · for · in order that · if… then · because — key words that link ideas to each other.

For (because, so, since) **points backward** ←
What comes after the “for” is the *reason* for what came before.

Therefore (thus, consequently, for this reason) **points forward** →
What comes after the “therefore” is the *implication* of what was said before.

> **Romans 8:1** ESV
>
> *In light of all Paul has said in Romans 1–7, “therefore”…*
>
> **Life in the Spirit**
>
> 8 There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.

COMPARISON / CONTRAST CONNECTORS

as well as · likewise · similarly (comparison) | **but · instead · or** (contrast)

SECTION 4 · PRACTICE 1

1 PETER 5:5–7

DISCOURSE The handout printed verses 6–7. Verse 5 is included because the "therefore" in verse 6 points back to it.

> **1 Peter 5:5–7** ESV
>
> 5 Likewise, you who are younger, be subject to the elders. Clothe yourselves, all of you, with humility toward one another, for "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble."
>
> 6 Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you, 7 casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you.

1. Circle the main verb in verse 6. What is its mood (statement, command, question)?

2. Underline the participle in verse 7. How does it support the main verb? (How do we humble ourselves?)

3. Box every connector (*therefore, so that, because*). What does each one link?

4. What is the reason given? What is the promised result?

5. Put the structure in one sentence: "Humble yourselves _____ by _____ because _____ so that _____."

Apply. What does it look like to *not* cast our anxieties on him? What would change this week if you did?

HEBREWS 12:1–13

DISCOURSE Read the passage and focus on the **connector words**. Mark each one and write in the margin what it is connecting.

Hebrews 12:1–13 ESV

Jesus, Founder and Perfecter of Our Faith

12 Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a
cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight,
and sin which clings so closely, and let us run with
endurance the race that is set before us, 2 looking to
Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who
for the joy that was set before him endured the
cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right
hand of the throne of God.

Do Not Grow Weary

3 Consider him who endured from sinners such
hostility against himself, so that you may not grow
weary or fainthearted. 4 In your struggle against sin
you have not yet resisted to the point of shedding
your blood. 5 And have you forgotten the
exhortation that addresses you as sons?

"My son, do not regard lightly the discipline of the
Lord,
nor be weary when reproved by him.

6 For the Lord disciplines the one he loves,
and chastises every son whom he receives."

7 It is for discipline that you have to endure. God is
treating you as sons. For what son is there whom his
father does not discipline? 8 If you are left without
discipline, in which all have participated, then you
are illegitimate children and not sons. 9 Besides this,
we have had earthly fathers who disciplined us and
we respected them. Shall we not much more be
subject to the Father of spirits and live? 10 For they
disciplined us for a short time as it seemed best to
them, but he disciplines us for our good, that we
may share his holiness. 11 For the moment all
discipline seems painful rather than pleasant, but
later it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to
those who have been trained by it.

12 Therefore lift your drooping hands and strengthen
your weak knees, 13 and make straight paths for your
feet, so that what is lame may not be put out of joint
but rather be healed.

Verse	Connector	What is it connecting?

SECTION 4 · PRACTICE 2 · LEVEL UP

HEBREWS 12: THE FLOW OF THOUGHT

Keep listing connectors here if you ran out of room:

Verse	Connector	What is it connecting?

Then: look at the main verbs. Where does the passage change from one main idea to the next? Give each section a short title.

Verses	Key verb / idea	Title
vv. _____		
vv. _____		
vv. _____		

Discuss. What was going on in the church this author was writing to? How does the structure move them to endure?

Apply. Where do you need to "lift your drooping hands" this week?

PSALM 23: IMAGERY

POETRY **Imagery is the key tool in poetry.** As the psalm is read aloud, listen for the pictures. Where does the picture change? A change in the image usually marks a change in the structure.

Psalm 23 ESV

The Lord Is My Shepherd

A Psalm of David.

23 The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want.
2 He makes me lie down in green pastures.
He leads me beside still waters.
3 He restores my soul.
He leads me in paths of righteousness
for his name's sake.
4 Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death,
I will fear no evil,
for you are with me;
your rod and your staff,
they comfort me.
5 You prepare a table before me
in the presence of my enemies;
you anoint my head with oil;
my cup overflows.
6 Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me
all the days of my life,
and I shall dwell in the house of the Lord
forever.

Verses	Image of God	Image of me / us	Details in the picture
vv. _____			
vv. _____			

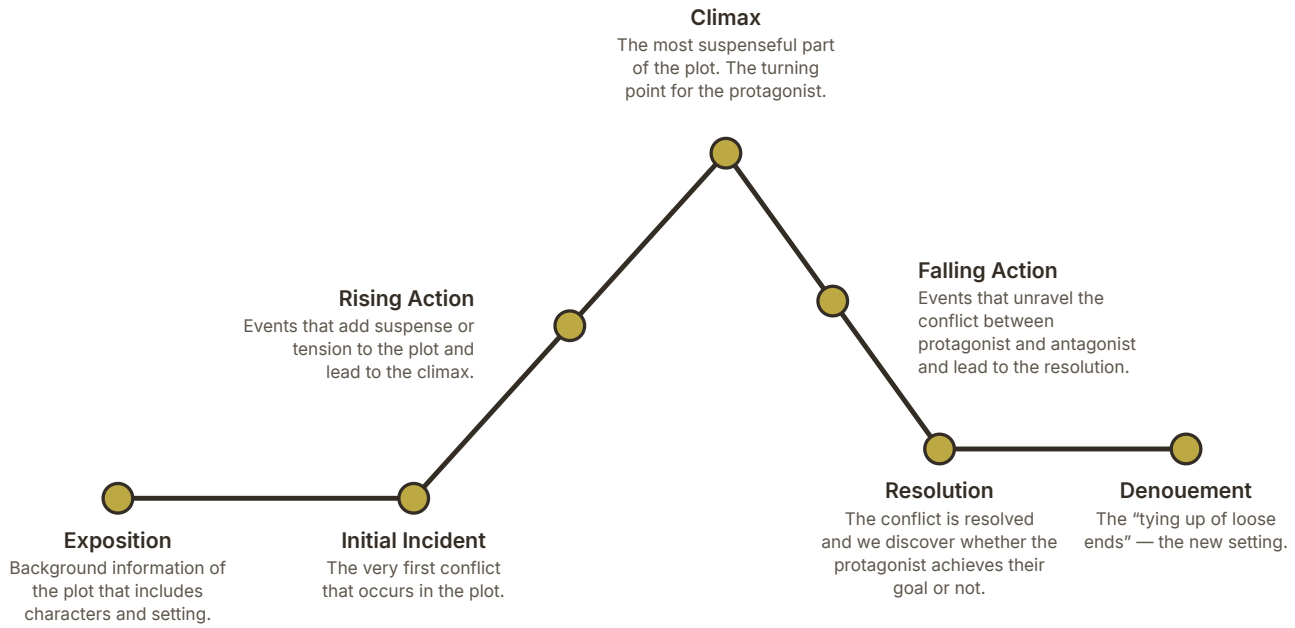
1. Where does the image shift? What changes about the setting and the danger?

2. If you taught this psalm, how could the two images become the two movements of your lesson?

3. Notice the change from "he" (vv. 2–3) to "you" (vv. 4–5). Why might that matter?

THE NARRATIVE ARC

NARRATIVE **Every story has a narrative arc.** A story has an initial setting, an inciting incident when tension first appears, rising action, a climax where the tension is highest, a resolution, and a new setting.



Where's the emphasis? In a narrative, the main idea is usually found in one of two places: **at the climax**, or **in the change between the old setting and the new setting.**

WARM-UP: TRACE A STORY EVERYONE KNOWS

Lincoln used *Cinderella* (not in the Bible, he admits). Fill in the arc together:

Stage	Cinderella
Exposition / setting	
Initial incident	
Rising action	
Climax	
Resolution / new setting	

You'll use this arc on Judges 16 in Section 10.

CONTEXT CLUES

Judges and Ruth are two of the hardest narrative books for most people to read. Ruth depends on Judges, so start there.

1 · PAY ATTENTION TO NAMES

Names usually communicate theology. Gideon refuses to be king…

> **Judges 8:22–23** ESV
>
> **Gideon's Ephod**
>
> 22 Then the men of Israel said to Gideon, "Rule over us, you and your son and your grandson also, for you have saved us from the hand of Midian." 23 Gideon said to them, "I will not rule over you, and my son will not rule over you; the LORD will rule over you."

…and then names his son *Abimelech*, "my father is king." What does that tell you?

> **Judges 8:30–31** ESV
>
> 30 Now Gideon had seventy sons, his own offspring, for he had many wives. 31 And his concubine who was in Shechem also bore him a son, and he called his name Abimelech.

2 · ISRAEL IS TRIBAL, NOT NATIONAL

Judges shows a divided tribal community that needs to become one nation under one king. Watch for tribal infighting (Manasseh in chs. 8–9, Ephraim in ch. 12, full civil war in ch. 20). It is never a good sign. Tribes also have a history: for a quick overview see Jacob's blessing of his sons in **Genesis 49**. In Judges, **Judah** is the model of faithfulness, **Benjamin** and **Dan** are the models of evil, and the other tribes are usually somewhere in between.

3 · INTERPRET IN LIGHT OF THE PENTATEUCH, ESPECIALLY DEUTERONOMY

> **Deuteronomy 17:16–17** ESV
>
> *Instructions for Israel's future king. Compare with Gideon above.*
>
> 16 Only he must not acquire many horses for himself or cause the people to return to Egypt in order to acquire many horses, since the LORD has said to you, 'You shall never return that way again.' 17 And he shall not acquire many wives for himself, lest his heart turn away, nor shall he acquire for himself excessive silver and gold.

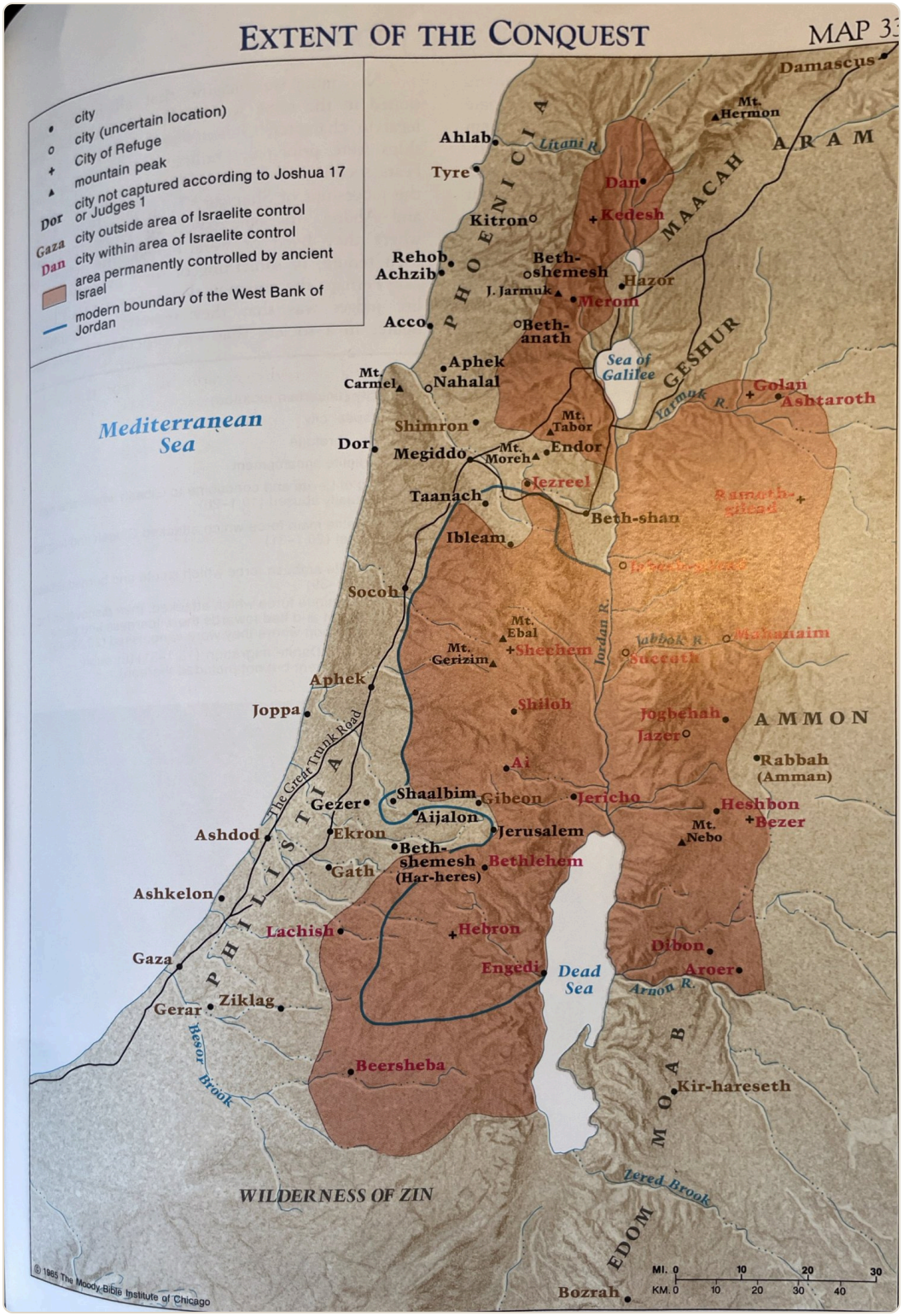
- **Pay attention any time life in the promised land feels broken** (famine, infertility, oppression). In Judges this is usually connected to idolatrous covenant breaking. (Be careful: we can't draw that same blunt line between someone's suffering and their sin today.)

4 · NOTICE GEOGRAPHY. GEOGRAPHY COMMUNICATES THEOLOGY.

See the maps on the next two pages.

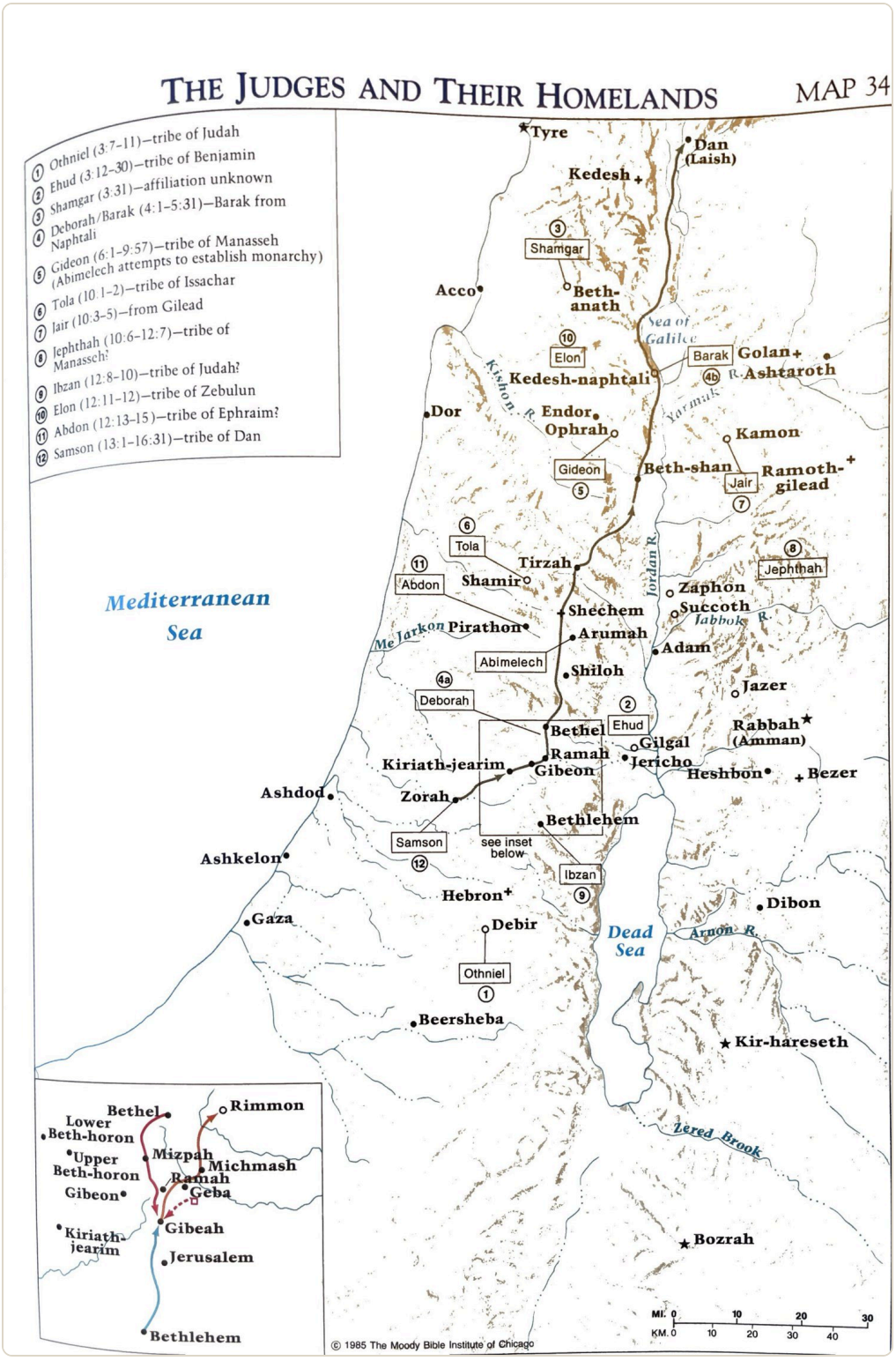
SECTION 8 · MAPS

EXTENT OF THE CONQUEST



What Lincoln pointed out: Israel took the **mountainous** hill country (shaded) but not the **flat coastal plain** to the west, where iron chariots dominated. Chariots of iron are mentioned some 13 times in Joshua and Judges, a technology that left Israel outnumbered and out-armed (Judges 1:19; 4:3). Generally in Judges, **south (Judah) = good stuff; the further north, the worse it gets.**

THE JUDGES AND THEIR HOMELANDS



Trace the flow: the book starts in the south and moves north. The first judge, **Othniel**, is from **Judah** (Debir, near Hebron) and is the model of godly leadership. The last judge, **Samson**, is from **Dan** (Zorah) and is the worst of them. Find each judge's homeland as you read.

SECTION 8 · GEOGRAPHY IN THE TEXT

IRON CHARIOTS

> **Judges 1:19** ESV
>
> [19] And the Lord was with Judah, and he took possession of the hill country, but he could not drive out the inhabitants of the plain because they had chariots of iron.

> **Judges 4:1–3** ESV
>
> **Deborah and Barak**
>
> **4** And the people of Israel again did what was evil in the sight of the Lord after Ehud died. [2] And the Lord sold them into the hand of Jabin king of Canaan, who reigned in Hazor. The commander of his army was Sisera, who lived in Harosheth-hagoyim. [3] Then the people of Israel cried out to the Lord for help, for he had 900 chariots of iron and he oppressed the people of Israel cruelly for twenty years.

1. Using the conquest map, where would 900 chariots of iron be most effective? Where would they be useless?

2. Why is the victory over Sisera in Judges 4–5 one of the high-water marks of the book?

Why this matters: it seems impossible for God's people to win. They are outnumbered and out-teched. With nothing but God on their side, they conquer. **Geography communicates theology.**

SECTION 9 · OTHER IMPORTANT TOOLS FOR STRUCTURE

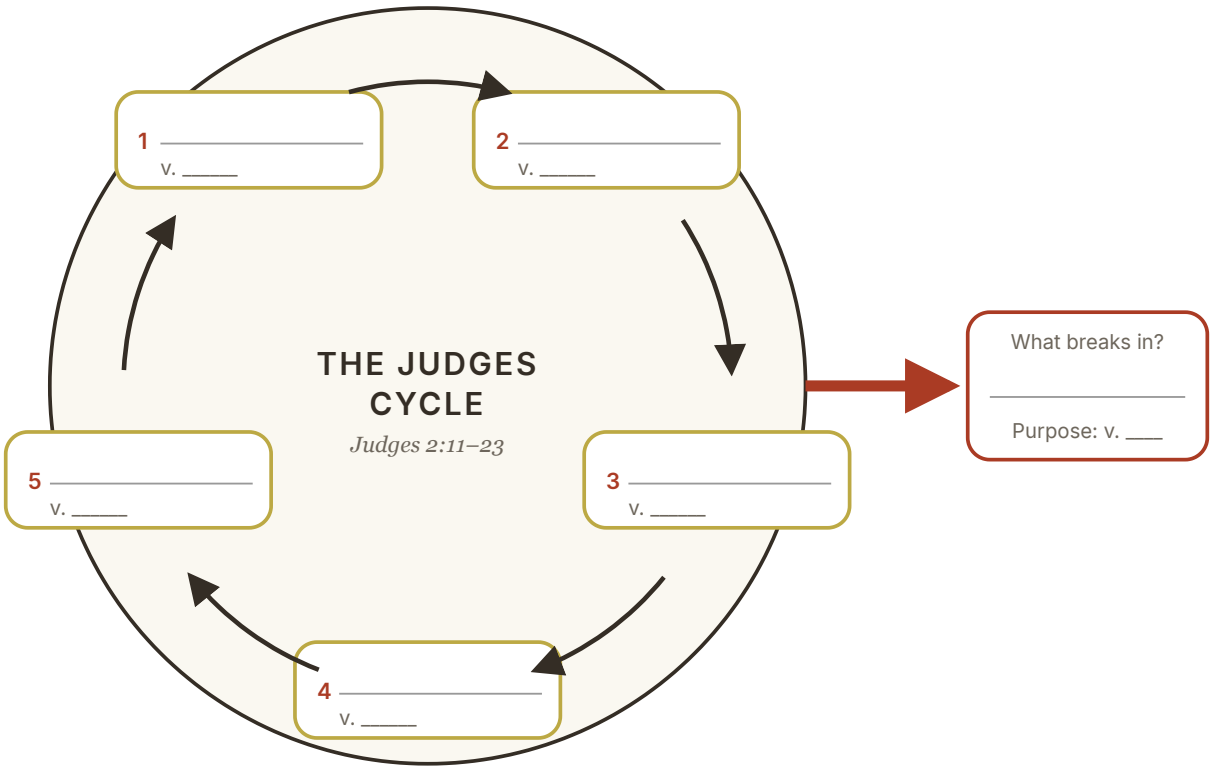
THE BIG PICTURE OF JUDGES

Each passage in Judges has a narrative arc, but **the whole book has a kind of narrative arc too.** These tools work alongside the narrative arc, which is still the key tool.

ON SCREEN · 1:14:57

The narrative arc is the key thing.

- **The macro structure:** Judges 1:1–7 & 21:24–25 (compare how the book begins and ends)
- **The book's pattern:** Judges 2:11–23 (the cycle below)



Fill in each step and one verse reference from Judges 2:11–23. Then: what is the purpose of the cycle?

- **The leaders represent the people.** As the leader goes, so go the people (see Judges 2:7–10).
- **Watch for the narrator's comment.** When the narrator steps out of the story to tell you something, he is usually giving you the reason for it, God's perspective on the events. ("In those days there was no king in Israel" — 17:6; 18:1; 19:1; 21:25.)

ON SCREEN · 1:15:35

The other key thing to look at for structure is the narrator's comment.

TOP AND TAIL: JUDGES 1 & 21

NARRATIVE You're doing an overview Bible study on Judges. Read the first seven verses and the last two verses. What's similar? What's different?

> **Judges 1:1–7** ESV
>
> **The Continuing Conquest of Canaan**
>
> 1 After the death of Joshua, the people of Israel inquired of the LORD, "Who shall go up first for us against the
> Canaanites, to fight against them?" 2 The LORD said, "Judah shall go up; behold, I have given the land into his
> hand." 3 And Judah said to Simeon his brother, "Come up with me into the territory allotted to me, that we
> may fight against the Canaanites. And I likewise will go with you into the territory allotted to you." So Simeon
> went with him. 4 Then Judah went up and the LORD gave the Canaanites and the Perizzites into their hand,
> and they defeated 10,000 of them at Bezek. 5 They found Adoni-bezek at Bezek and fought against him and
> defeated the Canaanites and the Perizzites. 6 Adoni-bezek fled, but they pursued him and caught him and cut
> off his thumbs and his big toes. 7 And Adoni-bezek said, "Seventy kings with their thumbs and their big toes
> cut off used to pick up scraps under my table. As I have done, so God has repaid me." And they brought him to
> Jerusalem, and he died there.

> **Judges 21:24–25** ESV
>
> 24 And the people of Israel departed from there at that time, every man to his tribe and family, and they went
> out from there every man to his inheritance.
>
> 25 In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.

How does it begin? (1:1–7)	How does it end? (21:24–25)

Discuss. If the beginning and end both lack a leader, what is the whole book about? Where does that longing point?

JUDGES 2:11–23: THE CYCLE

NARRATIVE Read the passage, then fill in the Judges Cycle on the next page with one verse reference for each step.

Judges 2:11–23 ESV

Israel's Unfaithfulness

11 And the people of Israel did what was evil in the
sight of the Lord and served the Baals. 12 And they
abandoned the Lord, the God of their fathers, who
had brought them out of the land of Egypt. They
went after other gods, from among the gods of the
peoples who were around them, and bowed down to
them. And they provoked the Lord to anger. 13 They
abandoned the Lord and served the Baals and the
Ashtaroth. 14 So the anger of the Lord was kindled
against Israel, and he gave them over to plunderers,
who plundered them. And he sold them into the
hand of their surrounding enemies, so that they
could no longer withstand their enemies.
15 Whenever they marched out, the hand of the Lord
was against them for harm, as the Lord had warned,
and as the Lord had sworn to them. And they were
in terrible distress.

The Lord Raises Up Judges

16 Then the Lord raised up judges, who saved them
out of the hand of those who plundered them. 17 Yet
they did not listen to their judges, for they whored
after other gods and bowed down to them. They
soon turned aside from the way in which their
fathers had walked, who had obeyed the
commandments of the Lord, and they did not do so.
18 Whenever the Lord raised up judges for them, the
Lord was with the judge, and he saved them from
the hand of their enemies all the days of the judge.
For the Lord was moved to pity by their groaning
because of those who afflicted and oppressed them.
19 But whenever the judge died, they turned back
and were more corrupt than their fathers, going
after other gods, serving them and bowing down to
them. They did not drop any of their practices or
their stubborn ways. 20 So the anger of the Lord was
kindled against Israel, and he said, "Because this
people have transgressed my covenant that I
commanded their fathers and have not obeyed my
voice, 21 I will no longer drive out before them any of
the nations that Joshua left when he died, 22 in
order to test Israel by them, whether they will take
care to walk in the way of the Lord as their fathers
did, or not." 23 So the Lord left those nations, not
driving them out quickly, and he did not give them
into the hand of Joshua.

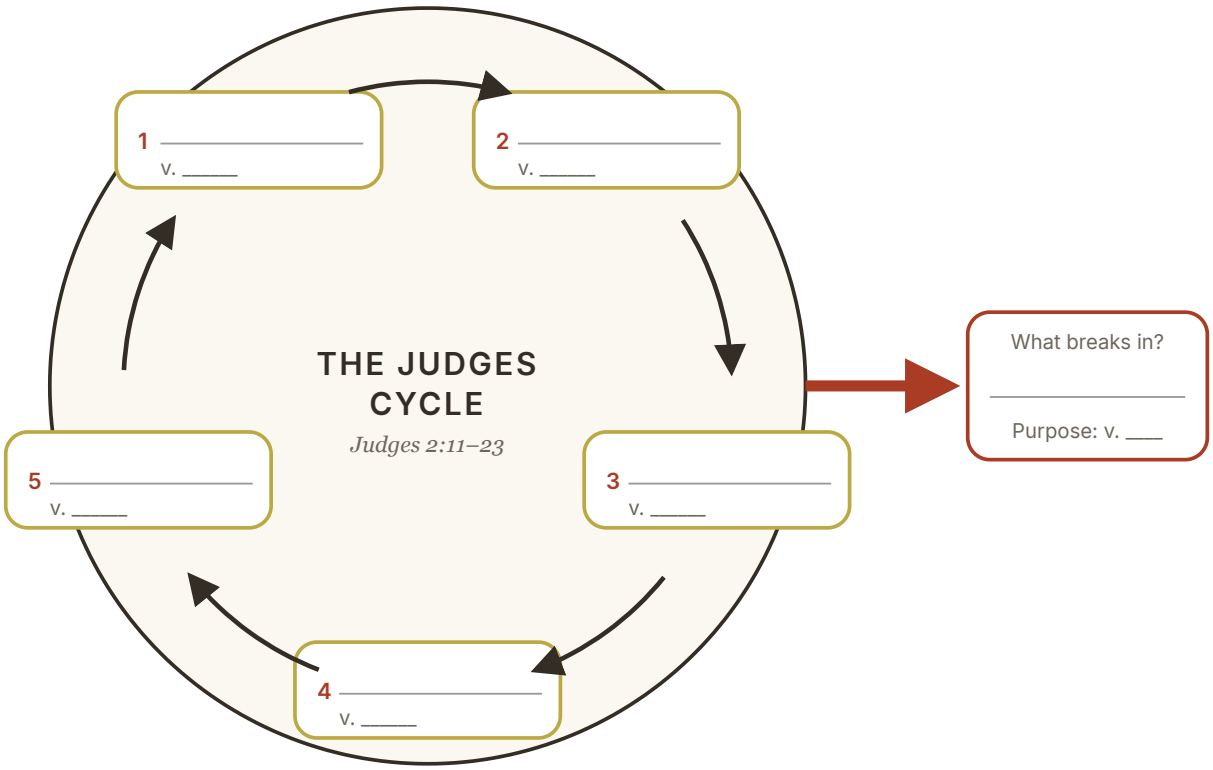
Judges 2:6–10 ESV

Optional context for "the leaders represent the people."

The Death of Joshua

6 When Joshua dismissed the people, the people of Israel went each to his inheritance to take possession of
the land. 7 And the people served the Lord all the days of Joshua, and all the days of the elders who outlived
Joshua, who had seen all the great work that the Lord had done for Israel. 8 And Joshua the son of Nun, the
servant of the Lord, died at the age of 110 years. 9 And they buried him within the boundaries of his
inheritance in Timnath-heres, in the hill country of Ephraim, north of the mountain of Gaash. 10 And all that
generation also were gathered to their fathers. And there arose another generation after them who did not
know the Lord or the work that he had done for Israel.

FILL IN THE CYCLE



1. When God's people cry out under oppression, what earlier book does that echo?

2. According to verses 21–22, why did the LORD leave the nations in the land? Where else have we seen "walking" language in this packet?

3. As the book goes on, the land has rest for fewer years under each judge. After Samson: zero. How does the cycle help you interpret each individual story?

JUDGES 16:1–31

NARRATIVE Read the whole chapter in your group and try to **trace the narrative arc**. Give a verse and some geography for each movement.

Judges 16:1–31 ESV

Samson and Delilah

16 Samson went to Gaza, and there he saw a
prostitute, and he went in to her. 2 The Gazites were
told, "Samson has come here." And they surrounded
the place and set an ambush for him all night at the
gate of the city. They kept quiet all night, saying,
"Let us wait till the light of the morning; then we will
kill him." 3 But Samson lay till midnight, and at
midnight he arose and took hold of the doors of the
gate of the city and the two posts, and pulled them
up, bar and all, and put them on his shoulders and
carried them to the top of the hill that is in front of
Hebron.

4 After this he loved a woman in the Valley of Sorek,
whose name was Delilah. 5 And the lords of the
Philistines came up to her and said to her, "Seduce
him, and see where his great strength lies, and by
what means we may overpower him, that we may
bind him to humble him. And we will each give you
1,100 pieces of silver." 6 So Delilah said to Samson,
"Please tell me where your great strength lies, and
how you might be bound, that one could subdue
you."

7 Samson said to her, "If they bind me with seven
fresh bowstrings that have not been dried, then I
shall become weak and be like any other man."
8 Then the lords of the Philistines brought up to her
seven fresh bowstrings that had not been dried, and
she bound him with them. 9 Now she had men lying
in ambush in an inner chamber. And she said to
him, "The Philistines are upon you, Samson!" But he
snapped the bowstrings, as a thread of flax snaps
when it touches the fire. So the secret of his strength
was not known.

10 Then Delilah said to Samson, "Behold, you have
mocked me and told me lies. Please tell me how you
might be bound." 11 And he said to her, "If they bind
me with new ropes that have not been used, then I
shall become weak and be like any other man." 12 So
Delilah took new ropes and bound him with them
and said to him, "The Philistines are upon you,
Samson!" And the men lying in ambush were in an
inner chamber. But he snapped the ropes off his
arms like a thread.

13 Then Delilah said to Samson, "Until now you have
mocked me and told me lies. Tell me how you might
be bound." And he said to her, "If you weave the
seven locks of my head with the web and fasten it
tight with the pin, then I shall become weak and be
like any other man." 14 So while he slept, Delilah
took the seven locks of his head and wove them into
the web. And she made them tight with the pin and
said to him, "The Philistines are upon you, Samson!"
But he awoke from his sleep and pulled away the
pin, the loom, and the web.

15 And she said to him, "How can you say, 'I love
you,' when your heart is not with me? You have
mocked me these three times, and you have not told
me where your great strength lies." 16 And when she
pressed him hard with her words day after day, and
urged him, his soul was vexed to death. 17 And he
told her all his heart, and said to her, "A razor has
never come upon my head, for I have been a Nazirite
to God from my mother's womb. If my head is
shaved, then my strength will leave me, and I shall
become weak and be like any other man."

18 When Delilah saw that he had told her all his
heart, she sent and called the lords of the Philistines,
saying, "Come up again, for he has told me all his
heart." Then the lords of the Philistines came up to
her and brought the money in their hands. 19 She
made him sleep on her knees. And she called a man
and had him shave off the seven locks of his head.
Then she began to torment him, and his strength left
him. 20 And she said, "The Philistines are upon you,
Samson!" And he awoke from his sleep and said, "I
will go out as at other times and shake myself free."

But he did not know that the LORD had left him.
21 And the Philistines seized him and gouged out his
eyes and brought him down to Gaza and bound him
with bronze shackles. And he ground at the mill in
the prison. 22 But the hair of his head began to grow
again after it had been shaved.

The Death of Samson

23 Now the lords of the Philistines gathered to offer a
great sacrifice to Dagon their god and to rejoice, and
they said, "Our god has given Samson our enemy
into our hand." 24 And when the people saw him,
they praised their god. For they said, "Our god has
given our enemy into our hand, the ravager of our
country, who has killed many of us." 25 And when
their hearts were merry, they said, "Call Samson,
that he may entertain us." So they called Samson out
of the prison, and he entertained them. They made
him stand between the pillars. 26 And Samson said
to the young man who held him by the hand, "Let
me feel the pillars on which the house rests, that I
may lean against them." 27 Now the house was full of
men and women. All the lords of the Philistines were
there, and on the roof there were about 3,000 men
and women, who looked on while Samson
entertained.

28 Then Samson called to the LORD and said, "O Lord
GOD, please remember me and please strengthen me
only this once, O God, that I may be avenged on the
Philistines for my two eyes." 29 And Samson grasped
the two middle pillars on which the house rested,
and he leaned his weight against them, his right
hand on the one and his left hand on the other.
30 And Samson said, "Let me die with the
Philistines." Then he bowed with all his strength,
and the house fell upon the lords and upon all the
people who were in it. So the dead whom he killed at
his death were more than those whom he had killed
during his life. 31 Then his brothers and all his family
came down and took him and brought him up and
buried him between Zorah and Eshtaol in the tomb
of Manoah his father. He had judged Israel twenty
years.

TRACING JUDGES 16

Stage	Verses	Where?	What happens?
Setting			
Initial incident			
Rising action			
Climax			
Resolution / new setting			

1. What phrase is repeated between verses 15 and 18? What does Samson finally give up?

2. Compare the old setting (vv. 1–3) with the new setting at the end. What changed, and why?

3. As the leaders go, so go the people. How might this chapter sum up the story of Israel in the whole book?

4. Where do you see the context clues at work here (names, tribe of Dan, geography, the cycle and "rest")?

SECTION 10 · PRACTICE 7

RUTH 1:1–5

NARRATIVE As the passage is read aloud, listen for anything that pops out. Use the context clues from Judges.

> **Ruth 1:1–5** ESV
>
> **Naomi Widowed**
>
> 1 In the days when the judges ruled there was a famine in the land, and a man of Bethlehem in Judah went to
> sojourn in the country of Moab, he and his wife and his two sons. 2 The name of the man was Elimelech and
> the name of his wife Naomi, and the names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion. They were Ephrathites
> from Bethlehem in Judah. They went into the country of Moab and remained there. 3 But Elimelech, the
> husband of Naomi, died, and she was left with her two sons. 4 These took Moabite wives; the name of the one
> was Orpah and the name of the other Ruth. They lived there about ten years, 5 and both Mahlon and Chilion
> died, so that the woman was left without her two sons and her husband.

1. "In the days when the judges ruled… there was a famine in the land." In light of Deuteronomy, what might a famine in the promised land mean?

> **Deuteronomy 28:15–18** ESV
>
> **Curses for Disobedience**
>
> 15 "But if you will not obey the voice of the LORD your God or be careful to do all his commandments and his
> statutes that I command you today, then all these curses shall come upon you and overtake you. 16 Cursed
> shall you be in the city, and cursed shall you be in the field. 17 Cursed shall be your basket and your kneading
> bowl. 18 Cursed shall be the fruit of your womb and the fruit of your ground, the increase of your herds and the
> young of your flock.

2. Where is Moab (find it on the maps)? What does it mean that this family goes there?

3. Look up what Naomi asks to be called at the end of chapter 1 (1:20). Compare the opening (famine, emptiness) with how the book ends:

> **Ruth 4:17** ESV
>
> 17 And the women of the neighborhood gave him a name, saying, "A son has been born to Naomi." They named
> him Obed. He was the father of Jesse, the father of David.

Discuss. Ruth opens with famine and death in the time of the judges and ends with the family line of David, the king Judges longed for. What does that change of setting tell you about the book's main idea?

SECTION 11

LEADER NOTES

- **Name the text type first.** Most confusion comes from using the wrong tool.
- **Ask for a verse.** When someone makes an observation, ask, "Where do you see that?" Keep the group in the text.
- **Let them find it.** Give groups a few minutes on a passage before you share answers.
- **Aim for one sentence.** End each passage by stating its structure and main idea in one sentence.
- **Describe ≠ prescribe.** Judges shows an x-ray of the human heart. What the Bible describes, it doesn't always prescribe.
- **Point to Christ.** Judges keeps showing the failure of human leaders. The ultimate leader of God's people is Jesus.

Answer guide (from the session)

Passage	What Lincoln drew out
1 Peter 5:6–7	Main verb is the imperative *humble yourselves*; *therefore* points back to v. 5 ("God… gives grace to the humble"). The participle *casting* supports it: we humble ourselves *by* casting our anxieties on him (prayer). Reason: *because he cares for you*. Result: *so that* at the proper time he may exalt you. You go down so God may lift you up.
Hebrews 12:1–13	Connectors: *therefore, since* (v. 1), *for* (vv. 2, 6, 7, 10, 11), *so that* (vv. 3, 13), *if… then* (v. 8), *besides this* (v. 9), *but* (v. 11), *therefore* (v. 12). Three movements by key verb: **run** (vv. 1–3), **discipline** (vv. 4–11), **strengthen** (vv. 12–13).
Psalm 23	Two images: God as **shepherd** who leads us (vv. 1–4) and God as **host** who pours out blessing on us (vv. 5–6).
Judges 1 & 21	Beginning: Joshua is dead, no leader, but Israel is united, consults the LORD and conquers together. End: no king, everyone did what was right in his own eyes. A book about leadership: as the leader goes, so go the people; it longs for godly leadership, ultimately Christ.
Judges Cycle (2:11–23)	1 Israel serves idols (vv. 11–13) → 2 the LORD's anger; he gives them over to enemies (vv. 14–15, 20) → 3 distress; they cry out / groan (vv. 15, 18; echoes Exodus 2) → 4 the LORD is moved to pity and raises up judges who save them (vv. 16, 18) → 5 the judge dies and they turn back, worse than before (v. 19). Under a judge the land has rest; longer rest usually means a godlier judge. Purpose: to **test** Israel, whether they will walk in the way of the LORD (v. 22).
Judges 16	vv. 1–3 Gaza: epic victory (the gates). v. 4 Valley of Sorek: Delilah. Three seductions, then he "told her all his heart" (repeated vv. 15–18): he gives up his heart. Captured, blinded, back in Gaza (vv. 21–23). Death for Samson plus the Philistines. No rest for the land after Samson.
Ruth 1:1–5	Famine in the land in the time of the judges signals covenant unfaithfulness (Deut. 28). The family runs to Moab, a pagan country. Opens with famine and emptiness; ends with Ruth as great-grandmother of David.

NOTES & PERMISSIONS

CREDITS

Teaching: Lincoln Fitch, DiscipleMakers, Equipped Training: Understanding Structure, LEFC|U, Lancaster Evangelical Free Church, November 2, 2026. This packet is adapted from the session handout and recording for use in LEFC small groups.

Passages in teaching order: Matthew 28:18–20 · Romans 8:1 · 1 Peter 5:5–7 · Hebrews 12:1–13 · Psalm 23 · Judges 8:22–23, 30–31 · Deuteronomy 17:16–17 · Judges 1:19; 4:1–3 · Judges 1:1–7; 21:24–25 · Judges 2:11–23 (with 2:6–10) · Judges 16:1–31 · Ruth 1:1–5 · Deuteronomy 28:15–18 · Ruth 4:17.

Maps: "Extent of the Conquest" (Map 33) and "The Judges and Their Homelands" (Map 34), © 1985 The Moody Bible Institute of Chicago. Reproduced as distributed in the session for internal small-group study.

Quotation: Mortimer J. Adler and Charles Van Doren, *How to Read a Book*.

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